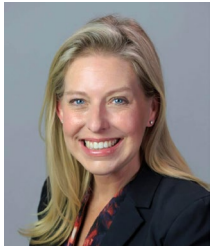
Community Engagement and Work Requirement Verification Implementation



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ARKANSAS DEPARTMENT OF HUMAN SERVICES

Community Engagement and Work Requirement



Why is this important?

Finding a job brings purpose, meaning, and economic independence, which leads to better health. Find your career, embrace your future, and learn more at **AR.gov/engage**

DHS

Community Engagement and Work Requirement

The federal budget bill signed into law last summer requires states to mandate that some Medicaid recipients and applicants demonstrate **community engagement** to receive benefits. States must be in compliance by Jan. 1, 2027 to continue receiving federal funds necessary to administer the Medicaid program for these beneficiaries.

Affected Population

Individuals aged 19-64 served by ARHOME, Arkansas' Medicaid expansion program and **who are not exempt**.

Why Start Preparation Now?

To **ensure coverage** for as many recipients as possible, thereby reducing the **risk of uncompensated care**, DHS needs time to establish a thoroughly tested verification system and **to educate ARHOME enrollees** on this change.

DHS

ARHOME Waiver Changes

More than 210,000 ARHOME recipients are subject to the Community Engagement and Work Requirements identified in the federal budget act, which will be required in the new ARHOME Waiver.



Engagement Hours Required

80 hours per month of one or more of the following activities:

1. Employment*
2. Work program participation
3. Educational enrollment
4. Community Service



Engagement Exemptions

Certain populations are **exempt** from federal requirements, for example:

1. Disabled veterans
2. Caregivers
3. Pregnant and Postpartum women
4. Special medical needs



Verification Details

States must determine if a Medicaid applicant met requirements first **upon application** and then again every **six months**. States are encouraged to use **available data** where possible, coupled with **outbound outreach.**

** ARHOME recipients can alternately meet the monthly employment requirement by earning at least $580 per month, which represents the federal minimum wage of $7.25/hour multiplied by 80 hours.*

DHS

Verification Implementation Overview

By **January 1, 2027**, DHS must implement a verification system and process for determining Community Engagement and Work Requirement compliance, non-compliance, or exemption.

How it will work

Automated Verification

DHS will first attempt an **automated, or *ex parte***, verification by checking data already available to the State (*e.g.*, wage data, SNAP applications).

DHS will log these automated checks in the Medicaid eligibility system and notify recipients of compliance status.

Outbound Verification Center

DHS is procuring a **Customer Service Center (CSC)** vendor, who will perform outbound calls to verify Community Engagement when the automated process cannot.

The vendor will accept information through various modes and **upload verification of compliance** to the system.

Verification Timeline

DHS is approaching the development of Community Engagement and Work Requirement verification in three phrases. Prior to Go-Live, DHS will not implement closures or penalties.

Phase 1
Sept. 2025 - Jun. 2026

Preparation & Testing

DHS shall develop the ***ex parte* infrastructure**, **prepare beneficiary communications**, and **educate State stakeholders** on ARHOME Waiver changes.

Phase 2
Jul. 2026 - Dec. 2026

Soft Implementation

DCO will **practice** implementing *ex parte* verification and **launch communications** to beneficiaries. The CSC vendor will **develop** and **test** the **outbound system** infrastructure. Beneficiary eligibility will not be impacted.

Phase 3
Jan. 1, 2027 - Ongoing

Verification Go-Live

ARHOME Waiver changes go live. **Closures and penalties** will be instituted beginning at go-live. **DCO** shall make **suspension determinations**. Life360 will continue during this period.

Soft Launch

On **July 1, 2026**, the State will begin a "practice" period for Community Engagement and Work Requirement verification **without penalties**. This soft launch will help the State **identify areas for improvement** and **help beneficiaries understand the new requirements.**

July 1, 2026

Automated processes begin

Automated verification for Community Engagement and Work Requirements **goes live**. Recipients will receive notice of compliance or noncompliance **without penalties**.

Beneficiary Communications

ARHOME beneficiaries begin **receiving targeted information** on Community Engagement and Work Requirements, system changes, and maintaining benefits through DHS and the CSC vendor.

Outbound System Build

The CSC vendor initiates the outbound system build and collaborates with DHS to **train CSC staff on non-automated verification** and outbound call management.

December 1, 2026

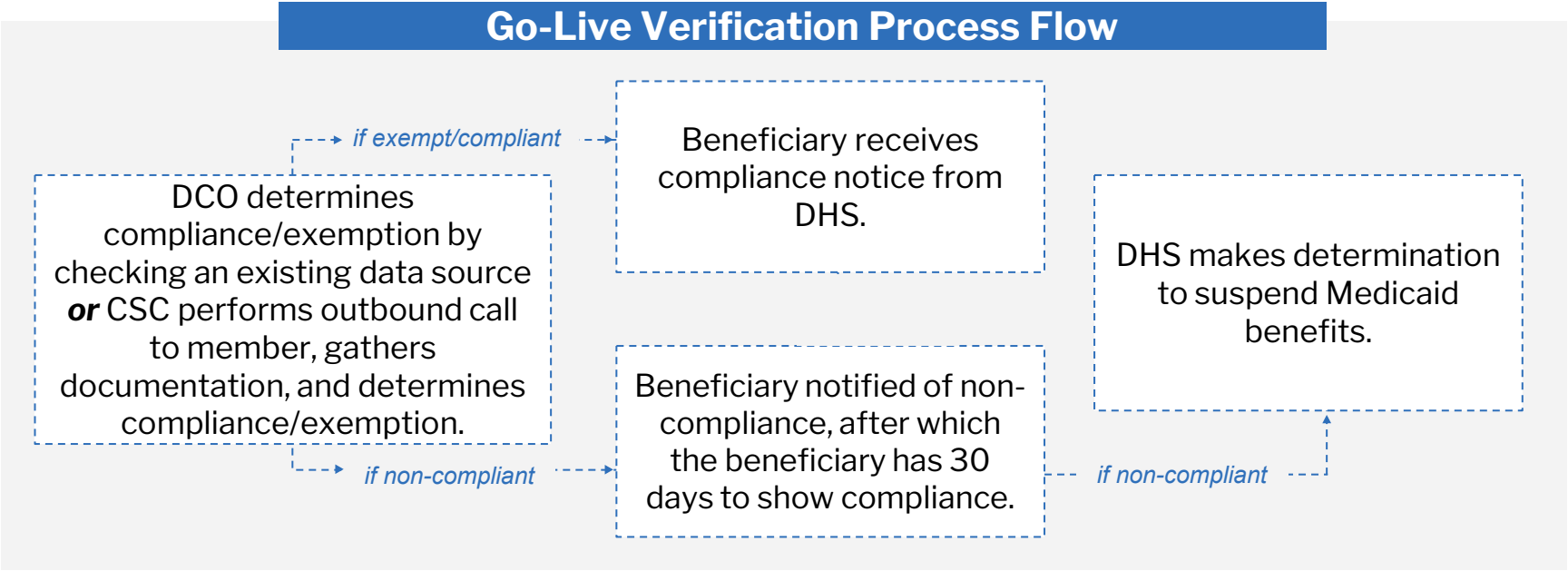
Outbound Implementation

The CSC vendor will **begin performing outbound communication** to obtain documentation verifying the status of ARHome beneficiaries as either exempt, compliant, or non-compliant.

DHS

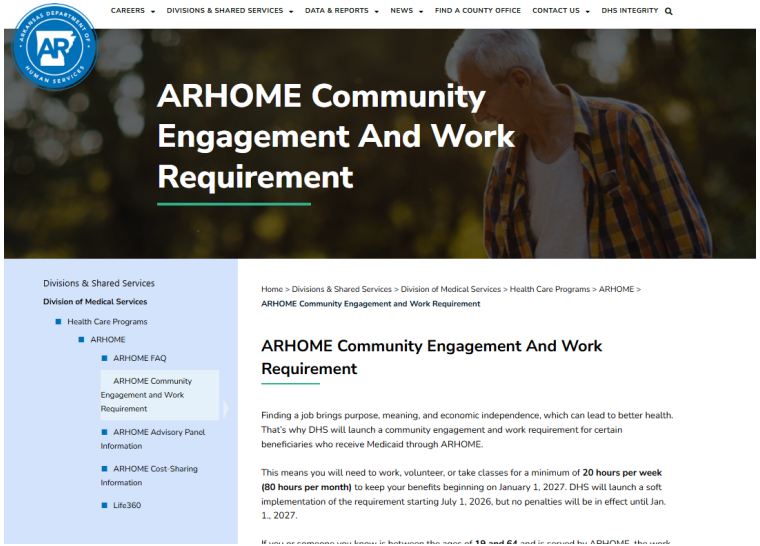
Full launch of program

On January 1, 2027, ARIES and the CSC vendor will continue performing Community Engagement and Work Requirement verification. Non-compliant members will receive **penalties** and **suspensions**.



Learn more

Additional resources are available at **ar.gov/engage**, and we will continue to update this website with additional information.





DHS

Frequently Asked Questions

Could this program still change?

- The overall aim of the program to require ARHOME beneficiaries to work, volunteer, or take classes **will not change**.
- However, there may be some adjustments in how the program is implemented.
- We are awaiting additional guidance from the Centers for Medicare and Medicaid Services, the federal agency that oversees Medicaid across all states.
- The soft launch is an opportunity to test systems and improve our program, and we may make changes based upon this feedback.
- We will share updates at **ar.gov/engage**, and also through direct communications with beneficiaries. Now is the time to make sure your contact information is updated.

Frequently Asked Questions

What are the exemptions?

You may be exempt if:

- You are pregnant or entitled to postpartum medical assistance
- You are under 19 or over 64
- You are a former foster child under 26
- You are a tribal member or Alaska Native
- You are a veteran with rated disabilities
- You are a medically frail individual
- You are participating in a substance use or alcohol use disorder treatment program
- You meet the TANF/SNAP work requirement
- You are a parent or caregiver of a dependent child aged 13 or younger, or someone with a disability
- You are entitled to or enrolled in Medicare Part A or enrolled in Medicare Part B

Frequently Asked Questions

How is this different from Arkansas Works, the previous work requirement that was in effect in 2018?

- The 2018 program required monthly reporting / attestation by beneficiaries. The ARHOME community engagement and work requirement will require demonstration of compliance or exemption at application and at renewal.
- The new requirement relies first on an automated check and will then move to a Customer Service Center that will reach out to beneficiaries.
- Arkansas also now has an integrated online eligibility system with a portal for beneficiaries called **Access Arkansas** through which beneficiaries can manage their cases, submit applications or renewals, receive notices, and provide any needed documentation.

Frequently Asked Questions

What lessons learned from the 2018 requirement have been applied to this new program?

- Two key takeaways from Arkansas Works were the **need to provide clear communications** through multiple means and the **need for simplicity in design and personal interaction** rather than overreliance on technology.

- We are communicating with beneficiaries in a variety of ways to ensure they are prepared for the new requirement. This includes notices, emails and texts, outreach from the customer service center, posts on social media, digital bulletin board in our offices, news releases, town halls like this one, and more.

- The simplicity in design and personal interaction have informed the plan for the customer service center. And beneficiaries whose circumstances cannot be verified through data sources will be able to provide information online, by visiting a local county office, or sending in documents through regular mail or email.

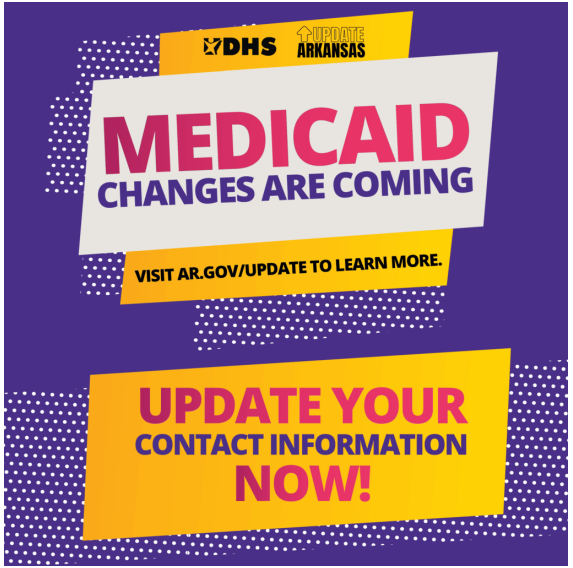
Frequently Asked Questions

If I have to report information to show compliance with the requirement, how do I do it?

- DHS will first attempt to use existing data sources to confirm you meet the requirement automatically.
- If this is successful, you will be notified and **you won't have to report anything at all**.
- If you need to report some information to determine compliance, a representative from the Customer Service Center will reach out. They will explain what is needed and how to report it.
- At that point, you may need to report online, by phone, or in person.

Frequently Asked Questions

How do I update my information to ensure you can reach me?



- Call the Access Arkansas hotline at **1-855-372-1084**
- Go online at **access.arkansas.gov** or **ar.gov/accessanywhere**
- Visit your local DHS county office to update your information. Find the addresses of all county offices at **humanservices.arkansas.gov**
- You can also sign up for email and text alerts using your Access Arkansas account. Watch a video detailing how to do this at **ar.gov/update**.

Community Engagement and Work Requirement

Questions?